

Intracavernosal Injections (Penile Injections for ED)

Patient Information · A shot you give yourself for erection problems

WARWIKI

Penile injections treat erection problems. You use a tiny needle to put a small amount of medicine into the side of the penis. This gives an erection. It can be a first choice, or an option when erection pills do not work or are not safe for you. The needle is very small, and most men feel only a small pinch.

About This Treatment

The medicine is often **alprostadil**, or a mix of two or three medicines made by a pharmacy (**bimix** or **trimix**). It relaxes the blood vessels in the penis so blood flows in. It works **even without sexual arousal**. The erection usually starts in about **5–15 minutes** and should last less than an hour.

- Your **first dose is given in the office**. Your team finds the right amount and watches until the erection goes away.
- You are then taught to **inject yourself at home**.
- It often works when pills have failed, including after prostate surgery.

Benefits and Risks in Numbers

9 in 10

men using the three-medicine mix could have sex in one large study

1–2 in 100

get an erection that lasts too long and needs treatment

about half

stop using injections, most within the first few months

Numbers are averages from published studies. Your own risk may differ; ask your team.

Is It Safe?

For most men, yes, when the dose is set carefully. The most important risk is an **erection that lasts too long (priapism)**. This is an emergency. Other effects include an ache in the penis (common with alprostadil), bruising, and, over time, firm spots of scar tissue. Switching sides each time helps prevent scarring.

Learn the Terms

Erectile dysfunction (ED)

Trouble getting or keeping an erection firm enough for sex.

Intracavernosal

Into the two spongy erection chambers of the penis.

Alprostadil

A common single medicine used for these shots.

Bimix or trimix

A mix of two or three medicines, made by a pharmacy.

Dose finding

Working out the right amount for you, starting in the office.

Priapism

An erection that will not go down. After 4 hours it is an emergency.

Erection pills

Medicines such as sildenafil or tadalafil.

Will it hurt? The needle is very fine. It goes into the side of the shaft, not the top or underside, and most men feel only a small pinch. A mild ache afterward is common, especially with alprostadil. Tell your team if it bothers you; a different mix may help.

How to Use It Safely

- 1 Use the dose your team wrote down. Do not change it, or take a second shot for a weak erection, unless your written plan says how.
- 2 Inject into the **side of the shaft**, away from visible veins. Avoid the top and the underside. **Switch sides** each time.
- 3 Press on the spot for about 5 minutes, or until any bleeding stops.
- 4 Use it **no more than 3 times a week**, with at least 24 hours between shots.
- 5 Do not use it on the same day as an erection pill unless your team says so.

Getting Ready

- Store the medicine exactly as the pharmacy tells you.
- Tell your team if you take a **blood thinner** or have a bleeding problem, have heart disease, or have sickle cell disease or trait or a blood cancer.
- Tell your team about any curve or lump in the penis. Never use injections if you have a penile implant.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- A new firm lump, or a new curve in the penis
- Pain, bruising or swelling that is getting worse
- Injections that stop working

Go to an emergency department if:

- An erection has not gone down **4 hours** after the shot. Go sooner if it is hard and very painful.
- You faint, or have chest pain or trouble breathing
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Tell the emergency staff which medicine and dose you used.

Three Things to Remember

1. Injections give a reliable erection in 5–15 minutes, even when pills fail.
2. Follow your written dose plan, switch sides, and use it no more than 3 times a week.
3. Early worries are normal. Call your team before you give up.